

 **Pi Puppis**
4,395 Suns

 **Naos**
12,555 Suns

PUPPIS THE STERN

A MAJOR SOUTHERN CONSTELLATION FOUND NEXT TO CANIS MAJOR, PUPPIS WAS ORIGINALLY DESCRIBED AS PART OF THE MUCH LARGER CONSTELLATION KNOWN TO THE ANCIENT GREEKS AS ARGO NAVIS, THE SHIP. PUPPIS CONTAINS SEVERAL STAR CLUSTERS VISIBLE WITH BINOCULARS AND SMALL TELESCOPES.

For the ancient Greeks, Puppis represented the stern, or poop, of the legendary ship *Argo* in which Jason and his crew sailed on the quest for the golden fleece.

The early Greek astronomers visualized *Argo* as a single large constellation, but in the 1750s it was divided into three by the French astronomer Nicholas Louis de Lacaille. The other two parts of the “ship” are the constellations Carina, the hull, and Vela, the sails. Puppis is the largest of the three. However, the brightest stars of *Argo* are within Carina and Vela, leaving Puppis with

only second-magnitude Naos, named for the Greek word for ship, as the brightest member of the constellation.

Two major star clusters in the north of the constellation create a bright patch in the stream of the Milky Way that runs through here. M47 is the closer and larger of the two, about 1,500 light-years away. Next to it lies M46, over three times as distant and hence more difficult to resolve into individual stars. In the far south of the constellation, NGC 2477 is an even richer and brighter cluster.

KEY DATA

Size ranking	20
Brightest stars	Naos (ζ) 2.2, Pi (π) 2.7
Genitive	Puppis
Abbreviation	Pup
Highest in sky at 10pm	January–February
Fully visible	39°N–90°S

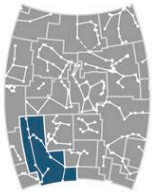


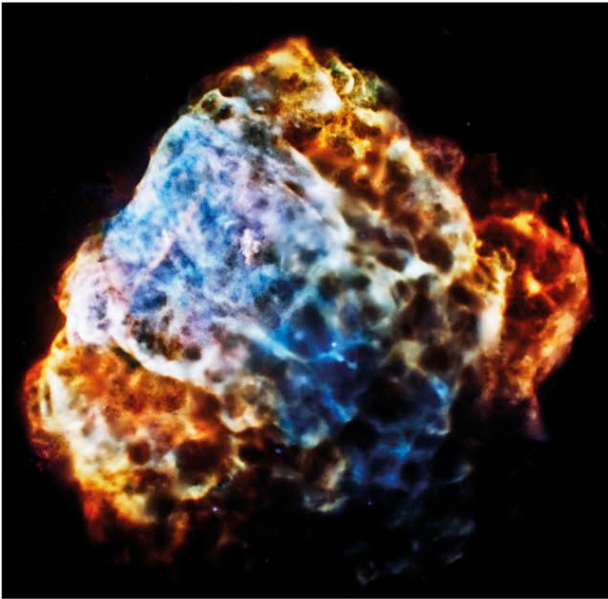
CHART 6

MAIN STARS

Naos (ζ) Puppis	Blue-white supergiant
2.2	1,080 light-years
Pi (π) Puppis	Orange supergiant
2.7	800 light-years
Rho (ρ) Puppis	White giant
2.8	64 light-years
Tau (τ) Puppis	Yellow-orange giant
2.9	182 light-years

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

M46	Open cluster
M47	Open cluster
M93	Open cluster
NGC 2440	Planetary nebula
NGC 2451	Open cluster
NGC 2452	Planetary nebula
NGC 2477	Open cluster
Puppis A	Supernova remnant



◁ **NGC 2452**
The blue haze in this Hubble Space Telescope image is what remains of the outer layers of a star that have drifted off into space at the end of the star's life, forming a planetary nebula. At the center of the cloud lies the exposed core of the nebula's progenitor star.

◁ **Puppis A**
Seen here at X-ray wavelengths, Puppis A is the remains of a supernova explosion some 3,700 years ago. It lies about 7,000 light-years away, about eight times farther than the much larger supernova remnant in neighboring Vela.

▷ **Star distances**
The nearest star to Earth in this constellation's main pattern stars is Rho (ρ) Puppis, which is 64 light-years away. The most distant star is Xi (ξ) Puppis, which is 2,000 light-years from Earth, about 30 times farther away. Naos (ζ) Puppis, the constellation's brightest pattern star, is also one of the most distant at 1,080 light-years from Earth.

